

HABBINSON

PERSONALITY & ENTREPRENEURSHIP SCHOOL

— PARENT INTELLIGENCE REPORT

How to protect your child's imagination

Your child's imagination is their superpower. Learn why it matters, what kills it, and 5 simple ways to protect it — plus the Disney story every parent should know.

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THE CHALLENGE PARENTS FACE

Your child's imagination can turn a cardboard box into a spaceship in seconds. One minute it's rubbish for the bin; the next, they're blasting past the moon and telling you, with total seriousness, that it follows them home. And somewhere inside you, a tired grown-up voice wants to say, "That's not real." Resist that v

— THE 30-SECOND ANSWER

How to protect your child's imagination

QUICK ANSWER

Why does your child's imagination matter? Imagination is how children practise thinking, problem-solving, and handling emotions before they ever face the real thing. Through pretend play a child tests ideas, invents solutions, and builds confidence and language. Far from a distraction, it's one of the strongest foundations for learning, creativity, and communication later in life.

DO THIS

5 simple ways to protect your child's imagination

Work through these in order. Small, consistent reps beat one big push.

1**When they share a wild idea, say**

"Tell me more about that." Curiosity keeps the door open; judgement slams it shut.

2**Give open-ended things**

boxes, blocks, sticks, old clothes. The less a toy "does," the more a child must imagine.

3**Protect boredom**

Leave real empty time with no screen, and let them grumble their way into a game.

4**Play along**

Be the customer at their shop or the patient at their clinic — your belief makes their world feel real.

5**Praise the idea, not the neatness**

"What a wild idea!" beats "Stay in the lines."

— KEEP AN EYE OUT

What quietly kills a child's imagination

- ☒ Saying "that's not real" or "that's silly" when a child shares a wild idea.
- ☒ Over-scheduling, so there's never an empty, bored afternoon for invention.
- ☒ Too much screen time, which feeds a child stories instead of letting them build their own.
- ☒ Praising only neat, "correct" results instead of bold, original tries.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

Quick answers for parents

Why is my child's imagination so important?

Imagination is how children practise real-life thinking in a safe space. Through pretend play they solve problems, handle big feelings, build language, and grow confidence. Pediatricians link rich play to stronger brains and better self-control, so it's a foundation for learning — not a distraction from it.

How can I encourage my child's imagination at home?

Keep it simple. Offer open-ended things like boxes and blocks, protect screen-free boredom, play along with their make-believe, and respond to wild ideas with "tell me more" instead of "that's not real." These small, daily habits give imagination room to grow.

Did Walt Disney really get fired for lacking imagination?

Yes. Early in his career a newspaper editor reportedly let Disney go, saying he lacked imagination and original ideas. His first studio also went bankrupt. He kept creating anyway and went on to build one of the most imaginative companies in history — a reminder not to write off a creative child.

Is too much screen time bad for a child's imagination?

Screens aren't all bad, but heavy passive watching feeds children ready-made stories instead of letting them build their own. Trading some screen time for open-ended, screen-free play gives your child the empty space where imagination and invention actually happen.

My child has a huge imagination — should I worry?

A big imagination is a gift, not a problem. Vivid pretend play, imaginary friends, and wild stories are healthy signs of a developing mind. Your job isn't to rein it in but to protect it, while gently helping them tell the difference between pretend and real.

How does imagination help my child's future?

The ability to imagine — to see what isn't there yet — sits behind creativity, problem-solving, entrepreneurship, and great communication. A child who can dream up ideas and explain them vividly is set up to stand out in school, work, and life.

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